SUVENDU ADHIKARI, 55

1970: Born in Karkuli

1990s: Wins Kanthi Municipality poll on Cong. ticket (1995); joins TMC in 1998

2001-6: Loses Mugberia in 2001 state poll, Contai LS seat (2004); wins Kanthi Dakshin assembly seat (2006)

2007-08: Plays major role in Nandigram movement

2009: Wins Tamluk LS seat

2016: Wins Nandigram assembly seat

2020: Joins BJP

2021: Beats Mamata in Nandigram; named LoP

May 2026: Wins Bhabanipur and Nandigram (since relinquished); becomes CM

FIVE KEY CHALLENGES

1. Reviving Bengal's stagnant economy while handling the state's massive debt burden of Rs 7.71 lakh crore
2. Balancing promises like higher welfare scheme payouts with fiscal discipline
3. Managing influential counterweights and factional interests within the BJP, coordinating with the state party organisation and the RSS
4. Restoring law and order and ending political violence, eliminating "cut money" and curbing politicisation of police
5. Handling issues such as illegal infiltration without alienating Bengali Muslims or deepening communal tensions

THE CM'S TEAM THUS FAR



The Cabinet

Suvendu Adhikari, *Chief Minister of West Bengal*



Dilip Ghosh, *Minister of Panchayat and Rural Development, Agricultural Marketing, Animal Resource Development*



Agnimitra Paul, *Minister of Women and Child Welfare, Municipal Affairs, Urban Development*



Nisith Pramanik, *Minister of North Bengal Development, Sports and Youth Affairs*



Khudiram Tudu, *Minister of Tribal Development, Backward Classes Welfare, Minority Affairs and Madrassa Education*



Ashok Kirtania, *Minister of Food & Supplies, Cooperation*



State President, BJP

Samik Bhattacharya

Attracting industry will be Suvendu's chief—and toughest—task. West Bengal's share in India's foreign investment inflows remains a miserly 0.6 per cent at present

restoration of inter-state training for IAS and IPS officers, a five-year age relaxation in government recruitment, resumption of the delayed census process and the transfer of land to the Border Security Force for the completion of border fencing along Bangladesh.

The government simultaneously stressed stricter civic and administrative discipline. The Special Intensive Revision exercise may cast a shadow beyond the election, as it was first announced that people who do not figure on the electoral rolls would not be entitled to state benefits only to clarify later that this would not apply to those whose names may be missing in the rolls but who have applied for citizenship under the Citizenship (Amendment Act) or sought redressal under the tribunal. The government also declared that everyone was free to practise their religions peacefully, but blocking roads and loudspeaker-related inconvenience would not be tolerated except during festivals, and with legal permission. It did mandate the singing of Vande Mataram in schools. The government is also expected to address many of its big poll promises, including monthly allowances to women, their security, reopening investigation in cases such as the R.G. Kar rape and murder, and the implementation of the 7th Pay Commission. The impediment in this good intent? The state finances.

THE ECONOMIC IMPASSE

Though West Bengal is India's sixth-largest state economy, with a projected Gross State Domestic Product of Rs 21.8 lakh crore for FY27, its Rs 1.71 lakh per annum per capita income is 20 per cent lower than the national average of Rs 2.12 lakh. Compounding the challenge is the state's enormous debt of Rs 7.71 lakh crore, which places it fifth among all states. Bengal's share in India's foreign investment inflows, too, is a measly 0.7 per cent.